

From Russia with LONG LEGS

Blonde, blue eyed and white skinned. These long-legged beauties are everywhere, from Bollywood songs to corporate events, swirling fire, twirling swords, but mostly just dancing.

■ By Deepika Khatri and Kimi Dangor

Twenty-four-year-old Tasya is like many women her age. She loves dancing, shopping and hitting nightclubs after a long day's work. But this Ukrainian woman is doing all this in Mumbai—her adopted home for the past three years. Having grown up watching Bollywood movies, she grabbed the chance offered by the manager of her dance troupe Valey. "There's always something new in Bollywood," says the woman who has danced in *Don* and *Neil and Nikki*, and loves humming Hindi film ditties.

Like her, 21-year-old Lhea, who moves around with band-aids and cotton swabs—essential in her profession of shimmying down poles—also goes by a single name and is from the former Soviet Union. Learning Bharatnatyam from Alegria, an exotic dance centre in Latvia, she had never imagined that she would be working in India, on contract with one of the several entertainment companies that have sprouted to indulge the newly-moneyed Indian's undying fascination for blonde hair, blue eyes and long white legs.

It's a fascination catered to by 25-year-old Irina, who came four years ago from Moscow to meet friends in Goa. What started off as a love for partying, became a way to make some extra cash and do what she likes best—dance. Armed with a work visa, she started performing in music videos. "I

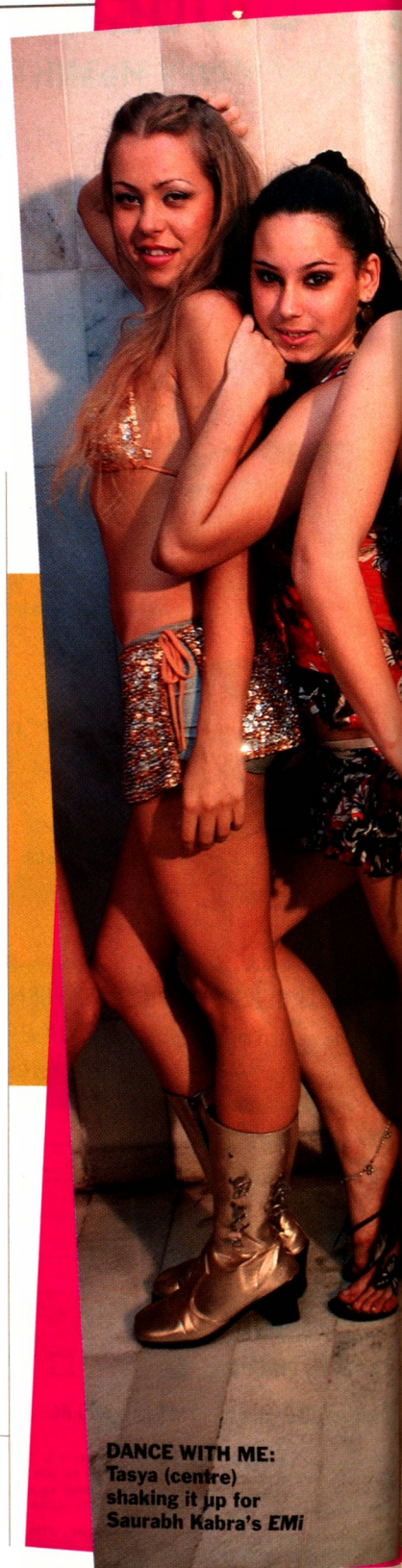
listened to Hindi music to familiarise myself with the language. Bollywood dancing has been a breeze, and if I'm not bored, I plan to continue," she says.

From dancing on bar tops at Goa's hotspots, playing hostess at corporate launches and doing a mean belly dance at Mumbai melees, these dancers from Russia, Ukraine, Belarus, even Azerbaijan, have now adopted Mumbai suburbs like Andheri, Oshiwara and Malad as their temporary homes. Such is the demand that from eight-odd dancers who would perform in events in 2001, Mumbai now hosts around 40 foreign dancers. And women like Annabell Paul, 36, find themselves on the speed dial of top Bollywood directors in search of allure and acrobatics. Paul, owner of Annabell Production, traces the trend to the *Koi mil gaya* song in *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai* in 1998. The next year saw *Mann* use foreigners as extras, followed by *Chori Chupke Chupke* in 2001. But it was Karan Johar's *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham* number *You are my Soniya* that was the turning point. Soon after, directors began demanding foreign artistes for movies like *Bewafaa* (2005)—which used 20 Russian dancers—*Kaal* and *Garam Masala*. By this time blonde blue-eyed women were coming to India on six-month and one-year contracts.

The dancers come from as far as Sweden, England and South Africa but girls from the former Soviet Union are preferred as they are cheaper and in-

"Bollywood trends are changing. Films are seeking a universal platform. If the subject is international, it will work anywhere."

ENAKSHI CHAKRABORTY, CEO, ESKIMO INDIA



DANCE WITH ME:
Tasya (centre)
shaking it up for
Saurabh Kabra's *EMI*